Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Robert Francis's "Catch"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of this poem include

alliteration,
analogy,
anaphora,
connotation,
controlling image,
denotation,
explication,
free verse,
imagery,
internal rhyme,
metaphor, extended metaphor,
meter,
onomatopoeia,
pun,
tenor and vehicle,
simile,
tone,
vehicle, and
word choice.

The contestant should choose to focus on the metaphor (or the controlling image) that is the poem's analogy. He or she might recognize in the metaphor the growing complexity and the intensification of a game of catch, which is the metaphor's vehicle. The increasing complexity that often characterizes a game of catch, which is essentially a practice session for a ballgame (the game is not specifically named), should be addressed as characterizing a student's, or more generally, a person's coming to know, to understand, a poem—a poem, poetry, being the tenor of the metaphor.

The young lit critter might catch the word *uncoached*, which should suggest that there is a naturalness involved in the experiencing of a poem—that, with practice, with exposure, comes understanding.

The crescendo from the ease of "tossing a poem" to the difficulty of "anything under the sun" the student should understand as a growing through experience so that, in time, with practice, the reader of a poem can explicate poetry, can catch the meaning of a difficult poem, a complex poem, as if the meaning were to be grasped like "a pretty one plump in [one's] hands."